MAHARASHTRA/NCP

THE PAWAR CUT THAT ISN'T?

By Dhaval Kulkarni

In what is seen as a battle of wits with nephew Ajit Pawar, Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) chief Sharad Pawar dropped a bombshell on May 2, saying he intends to quit as party president. The announcement, at the launch of an updated edition of his biography, comes at a time when Ajit is said to be in talks with the BJP, leading to a flux within the NCP.

Though Ajit vehemently denies the reports, sources say things could pick up pace after the Karnataka assembly election and the Supreme Court verdict on the cases regarding the June 2022 change of guard in Maharashtra, where Eknath Shinde and his band of rebels toppled the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) coalition of which the NCP was a part. An NCP group feeling the heat from the central investigation agencies is said to be eager to switch sides, with the effort being led by a national leader.

Pawar Sr's move is said to be an attempt to galvanise his forces and show Ajit who the boss is in the NCP. Alternatively, Pawar may be letting his nephew take over the reins in a détente to keep the NCP together. So, if the NCP decides to break ranks with the MVA, an emeritus status will help insulate him from responsibility. Pawar could even take the line that he is taking a 'democratic position', going with the wishes of the majority.

"Today, I have decided to step down as NCP president," said Pawar, taking the audience by surprise, adding that he would complete his Rajya Sabha term but would not contest elections in the future. The 82-year-old said that a panel of senior NCP leaders including Ajit, daughter Supriya Sule, Praful Patel, Sunil Tatkare and others would decide on the new party chief.

This led to immediate mayhem, with party leaders and workers thronging the dais and imploring Pawar to take back his decision even as he, flanked by wife Pratibha, sat almost sphinx-like on stage. NCP leaders like former minister and state president Jayant Patil even broke down. "In Maharashtra, we all seek votes in the name of Pawar *saheb*. The party gets votes due to him. If Pawar *saheb* steps aside, how will we face the people?" Patil asked, his voice quaking.

However, among all this there was one dissenting voice—Ajit. While his uncle was being beseeched, he

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asked those present to respect Pawar's decision. When Baramati MP Sule was asked to speak, Ajit promptly hushed her as her "*motha bhau* (elder brother)". "There is no need to be emotional. This was going to happen at some point," said Ajit, while revealing that Pawar had initially planned to make the announcement on May 1, but had postponed it by a day due to the MVA alliance meeting in Mumbai. In his trademark brusque style, Ajit snapped at people and, on one occasion, when a party worker threatened to launch a fast in protest, Ajit retorted: "Do it... *barik hoshil* (you will lose weight)!"



THE QUITTING GAME Ajit Pawar tries to calm party workers after Pawar Sr (centre) made his announcement

However, the chorus for Pawar Sr to withdraw his decision continued, making it evident that Ajit may be isolated in the party, at least for now. In fact, NCP functionaries across districts in Maharashtra began resigning from party posts in a move to persuade Pawar to reconsider. Ajit later told the media that Pawar had agreed to rethink his decision.

A senior Congress leader and former minister said this wasn't merely a leadership transition issue but a deeper "internal power struggle" with Sharad Pawar playing "emotional politics" to isolate Ajit. He felt the party would now "rally behind Pawar, showing Ajit who was the boss".

Such moves by Pawar have paid off in the past. In 2019, after the Enforcement Directorate (ED) booked